# Account lockouts: causes and how to unlock

Article KB0010004 | Owner: Service Desk L1 | Subcategory: Account locked | Applies to: Windows 11 23H2/24H2 laptops (Dell Latitude, Lenovo ThinkPad, HP EliteBook), macOS 14/15 devices using Microsoft Entra ID for SSO, Any Acme Global service that authenticates via Entra ID/AD (Outlook, Teams, VPN, PaperCut)

## Summary

This article explains why Acme Global user accounts become locked out, how end-users can resolve a lockout themselves, and the steps Service Desk L1 agents should follow to investigate, unlock, and prevent recurrence. It covers the 15-minute automatic lockout timer, self-service password reset, and common sources of stale credentials such as mobile mail apps, mapped drives, and scheduled tasks.

## Symptoms

- Login prompt shows "Your account has been locked out. Please try again later."
- "The referenced account is currently locked out and may not be logged on to." (Windows error 0x8007052E)
- SSO or Company Portal reports "Account is disabled" or "Sign-in blocked"
- Repeated requests for password after entering correct credentials
- Phone or tablet mail app continually asks for password and fails

## Common causes

- Cached username/password stored in mobile mail apps (iOS/Android Outlook, native mail)
- Mapped network drives or saved credentials using an expired password
- Scheduled tasks, services, or scripts running under the user account with stale credentials
- VPN (GlobalProtect) or Wi-Fi profiles retaining old password
- Credential Manager entries on Windows holding outdated passwords
- Multiple rapid failed attempts due to mistyped password or automated lockout scripts

## Self-Help: Unlock Your Account

If you receive a lockout message, you can often resolve it without contacting the Service Desk. The account lockout policy at Acme Global locks the account for 15 minutes after five consecutive failed logon attempts. During this window you can either wait for the lock to clear automatically or use the self-service password reset portal to choose a new password, which also clears the lockout.

1. Lock your workstation (Win+L) or sign out of any active sessions.
2. Wait 15 minutes - the lock will expire automatically.
3. If you need immediate access, open a browser and go to the self-service password reset portal: <https://passwordreset.acme.example>.
4. Select "I forgot my password" or "Unlock my account", enter your employee ID, and follow the prompts to verify identity via Microsoft Authenticator push or backup SMS.
5. Choose a new password that meets the 14-character complexity rule and does not reuse any of your last 10 passwords.
6. After the reset succeeds, try to log in again with the new password on your laptop or device.
7. If the lockout persists after 15 minutes or the reset fails, note any error messages and contact the Service Desk via phone ext. 4357 (HELP) or the Teams "IT Help" channel.

## Service-Desk Agent Procedure

When a user reports an account lockout, follow these steps to confirm the lockout source, unlock the account, and educate the user on preventing recurrence. All actions should be performed in accordance with Acme Global's identity management policies.

1. Verify the user's identity using standard verification (employee ID, manager confirmation, or MFA challenge).
2. Open Active Directory Users and Computers (ADUC) on a management workstation or run the PowerShell command: Get-ADUser -Identity <username> -Properties LockedOut to confirm the LockedOut attribute is True.
3. If LockedOut = True, unlock the account: right-click the user -> Properties -> Account -> Uncheck "Account is locked out" **or** run: Unlock-ADAccount -Identity <username>.

4. Identify potential sources of stale credentials:
- Ask the user to check mobile mail apps for saved credentials and remove/re-enter the password.
- Instruct the user to open Credential Manager (control keymgr.dll) and delete any entries for ACME resources.
- Have the user disconnect and reconnect mapped drives, or run `net use * /delete` followed by re-mapping with the current password.
- For VPN/Wi-Fi, tell the user to delete the GlobalProtect or wireless profile and recreate it using certificate-based authentication.
5. Advise the user to change their password via the self-service portal if they suspect the password was exposed, reinforcing the 14-character, 90-day expiry rule.
6. Document the ticket with: username, time of lockout, source of stale credentials (if found), actions taken, and any user-specific advice provided.
7. Close the ticket after confirming the user can successfully log in and complete MFA.

## Verification After Unlock

After performing the unlock, it is essential to verify that the account is functional and that the user can access all required services without triggering another lockout.

1. Ask the user to log in to their Windows laptop with the current password and confirm they reach the desktop.
2. Have the user launch Outlook and verify they can send/receive mail without being prompted for a password.
3. Test access to Teams, OneDrive, and SharePoint via the web or desktop clients.
4. If the user uses the VPN, request they connect to GlobalProtect and confirm connectivity.
5. Finally, ask the user to attempt a login after intentionally waiting a few minutes to ensure no automatic re-lock occurs.

## Preventing Future Lockouts

Most lockouts are caused by credentials cached somewhere outside the user's active session. Proactively clearing these caches reduces repeat incidents.

1. Regularly review and update passwords in mobile mail apps (Outlook, iOS Mail, Android Mail) whenever the corporate password changes.
2. Clear Windows Credential Manager entries for ACME services after each password change.
3. Re-map network drives using the option "Reconnect at sign-in" only after verifying the password is current.
4. Delete and recreate GlobalProtect or Wi-Fi profiles if the underlying certificate is renewed (yearly) to avoid password fallback.
5. Enable Microsoft Authenticator push notifications and register a backup SMS method to reduce reliance on password-only authentication for MFA.
6. Encourage users to use the self-service password reset portal at the first sign of a lockout rather than repeatedly trying the old password.

## Related Information and References

For further details, consult the following internal resources:

1. Self-service password reset portal: <https://passwordreset.acme.example>
2. GlobalProtect VPN client guide: <https://it.acme.example/vpn-guide>
3. PaperCut secure print release instructions: <https://it.acme.example/printing>
4. Microsoft Authenticator setup: <https://it.acme.example/mfa-setup>
5. Identity & Access Management (IAM) team contact: iam@acme.example

## When to escalate

If the account remains locked after the self-service reset, or if the user experiences repeated lockouts within a short period despite clearing known stale credentials, escalate the ticket to the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team. Include the username, exact timestamps of lockout events, any error codes captured, details of the stale-credential sources investigated, and relevant logs from Domain Controllers or Azure AD sign-in reports.

*Keywords: account lockout, locked out, AD lockout, password reset, stale credentials, credential manager, mapped drive, mobile mail, self-service password reset, Unlock-ADAccount, lockout threshold, MFA, GlobalProtect, VPN, Wi-Fi, Entra ID, Active Directory*